

GRINDING GEAR GAMES

A Heuristic evaluation of Path of Exile 2

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Strengthen Onboarding and Early Game Guidance for New Players

Improve Inventory Efficiency to Support Gameplay Flow

Standardize System Communication Across Interfaces

Contact info

Executive Summary



This evaluation is a comprehensive analysis of the user experience in Path of Exile 2, identifying several usability challenges that directly affect player retention, engagement longevity, and revenue potential. The findings indicate that many of the game's core interface components create unnecessary friction during key gameplay moments such as combat readability, item evaluation, the passive skill tree, and crafting interactions. These issues collectively increase cognitive load, slow player decision-making, and reduce confidence during progression. While the underlying systems are deep, rewarding, and well-designed, the current interface often obscures these strengths and introduces avoidable barriers that limit enjoyment for both new and returning players.

Across more than one hundred eighty survey responses, clear themes emerged regarding the pressures placed on players during high-demand scenarios. Many players noted that visual noise on screen makes it difficult to track threats, flasks, cooldowns, and ability cues. Others expressed that evaluating items remains a time-consuming process that disrupts gameplay flow and often pushes them toward external tools. The passive skill tree was frequently described as overwhelming, especially during early progression, which reflects an onboarding issue rather than a content issue. Crafting systems, while powerful, were consistently cited as intimidating due to limited predictive

feedback and unclear outcomes. Taken together, these factors create a disconnect between player expectations and the interface support needed to navigate PoE2's complex systems effectively.

These challenges have direct implications for Grinding Gear Games at the business level. Path of Exile 2 operates in a crowded and competitive ARPG market where clarity, accessibility, and immediate comprehension are essential for retaining new players. Retention is central to the long-term viability of any free-to-play model, since cosmetic revenue is strongly correlated with sustained player engagement. When friction accumulates early in a player's experience, it diminishes the likelihood of progressing to endgame systems where enthusiasm for cosmetics naturally increases. Reducing usability barriers, therefor,e represents a direct opportunity to strengthen revenue growth, increase player lifetime value, and secure a competitive position as PoE2 continues to evolve.

The recommendations provided in this report outline targeted solutions that address the most significant pain points identified by players. These solutions focus on improving perceptual clarity, reducing decision time, increasing navigational confidence, and strengthening communication of system behavior. Implementing these improvements will not only enhance the moment-to-moment gameplay experience but will also reinforce a more approachable progression curve that benefits both new players and long-standing community members. By investing in these refinements early, Grinding Gear Games can significantly improve the accessibility and long-term sustainability of Path of Exile 2, ensuring that its depth remains a draw rather than a barrier.



Introduction



The purpose of this evaluation is to examine how players interact with the core interface systems in Path of Exile 2 and to identify the usability factors that shape their overall experience. Because Path of Exile 2 is a complex action role-playing game with interconnected systems, players consistently rely on the interface to understand progression pathways, interpret game feedback, and make informed decisions during high-pressure encounters. This introduction outlines the objectives of the evaluation, the methods used to understand the player experience, and the key contextual factors that inform the subsequent analysis. The goal is to provide Grinding Gear Games with a clear, evidence-based understanding of how players navigate the existing interface and where usability improvements could meaningfully strengthen engagement, retention, and player satisfaction.

To achieve this, a contextual inquiry was conducted to gather direct input from players regarding how they use the product, what systems they depend on, and where they encounter friction. A combined quantitative and qualitative survey method was selected because it allowed for rapid collection of targeted insights from a large, motivated player base. The survey was initially distributed to a small group of experienced players, then later shared with the Path of Exile community on Reddit. The response rate grew quickly, resulting in more than one hundred eighty participants within a few hours. The only requirement to participate was that players had at least fifty hours of experience, ensuring that responses reflected meaningful interaction with the game rather than first impressions. This method proved highly effective for capturing patterns across a diverse range of play styles and experiences, and it produced consistent themes regarding the strengths and challenges of the current interface.

Understanding how players interact with Path of Exile 2 requires examining not only their attributes but also the situations in which they rely most heavily on the interface. Players come into the game with varying levels of ARPG experience, mechanical aptitude, and system mastery, yet they all depend on the interface to guide decision-

making during leveling, combat, item evaluation, crafting, and build planning. These scenarios represent the moments when usability has the greatest impact on performance and enjoyment. Players must be able to track critical information during combat, evaluate and equip items efficiently, understand crafting outcomes, and navigate an extensive passive skill tree. Each scenario places unique cognitive demands on the player, and the interface must act as a reliable support system during these high-information moments.

To support this analysis, a set of representative personas was developed to reflect the major segments of the Path of Exile 2 player base. These personas include Marcus, the returning veteran who values mastery and system depth. Elena, the mid-core strategist seeking efficiency and control. Rhys, the casual endgame explorer who engages intermittently but values clarity and quality of life. Adrian, the theorycrafter who thrives on optimization and long-term progression planning. And Samira, the enthusiastic newcomer entering the ARPG genre through Path of Exile 2. Together, these personas highlight the wide range of needs, expectations, and frustrations across the community. By designing recommendations around these groups, the evaluation ensures that proposed improvements support both seasoned players and those encountering the game's complexity for the first time.

From a business perspective, Grinding Gear Games benefits when the interface enables confident and intuitive engagement with the game's systems. Strong usability supports retention, which drives the long-term success of a free-to-play model that relies on sustained player investment. When friction accumulates early or when systems feel inaccessible, players are less likely to progress to endgame content, engage with the community, or spend money on cosmetic upgrades. Company objectives, therefore, align directly with reducing cognitive load, improving clarity, and supporting a smoother progression curve. Enhancing usability is not only a player experience initiative but also a strategic opportunity to strengthen revenue pathways and secure Path of Exile 2's position in a competitive ARPG market.

The remainder of this report builds upon the insights gathered in the contextual inquiry, identifying major usage assumptions, key usability violations, interface-level problems, and goal-driven friction points. Each section includes targeted recommendations supported by data and grounded in real player behavior. These insights form a comprehensive roadmap for refining the Path of Exile 2 experience and strengthening both player satisfaction and long-term engagement.



Contextual inquiry

What is a Contextual Inquiry?

A contextual inquiry is an exploratory user research method used to understand how individuals interact with a product in realistic use case settings. It focuses on identifying user goals, behaviors, contexts of use, and usability pain points through direct observation or structured questioning. Within the field of human factors, contextual inquiry is used to build domain knowledge, as it provides a background understanding of user characteristics and contexts that will later inform a heuristic evaluation.

Type Chosen & Rationale

I chose to go with a survey for my form of data collection. The survey I created collected both qualitative and quantitative data to capture a healthy balance of measurable usability factors and descriptive feedback. It was initially distributed to a small group of friends who had already played Path of Exile 2 both personally and on my friends list. It was then shared publicly on the Path of Exile Reddit page. The survey remained live for only a few hours but received an unexpectedly high level of support and participation from the community during that short period. I chose to go with a survey because it provided both a practical and efficient way to gather meaningful user insights about the game's interface, and due to availability restraints, most participants, when asked about doing an interview, were only available when I had class or work, so I adapted my interview questions into a survey to get their input. Path of Exile 2 has a large and very engaged player base, so even with the short survey period, it produced many responses. All participants were required to have at least twenty hours of gameplay experience to ensure that responses reflected genuine familiarity with the game's systems.

Objectives

The primary goal of this study was to understand how players interact with the complex systems of Path of Exile 2 and to identify areas where usability issues may occur. The study aimed to examine player motivations, determine how users navigate key systems such as the passive skill tree and inventory menus, and reveal design elements that contribute to confusion or frustration. Additional objectives included identifying perceptual and cognitive challenges and documenting user assumptions about clarity, feedback, and interface learnability.

Methods

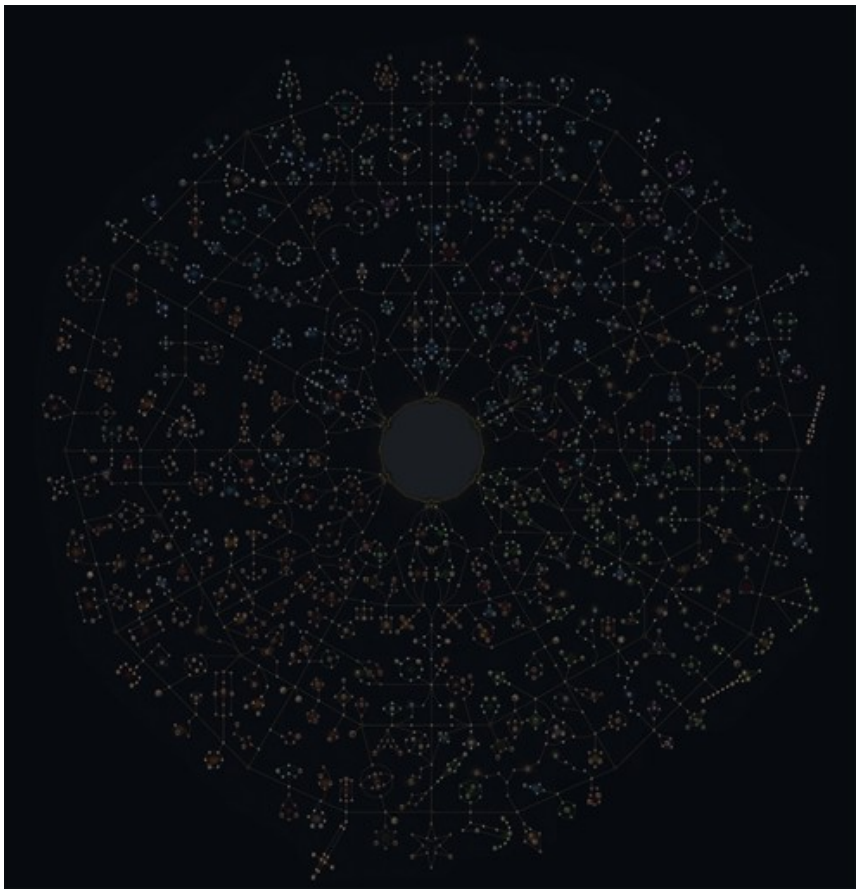
The survey was created and distributed using Google Forms. It included a combination of open-ended questions, which provided qualitative insights, and rating scale questions, which provided quantitative measures of usability. Participants were then also asked to describe their biggest frustrations and explain how confident they felt in interpreting in-game information. Participants were recruited in two stages. In the first stage, the survey was shared with a small group of friends who actively played Path of Exile 2. In the second stage, the survey was posted publicly on the Path of Exile Reddit page, where it quickly gained significant attention while I was at work. The survey

remained live for only a few hours but received an overwhelming level of support from the community. A total of one hundred eighty-three participants completed it, all of whom met the twenty-hour gameplay requirement.

Findings

Responses revealed that players were primarily motivated by character optimization, build experimentation, and mastering the game's mechanics to get the best build possible. Many players found satisfaction in testing new combinations of skills and improving performance through trial and error. The participants emphasized the importance of clear feedback and information accessibility, with many saying that the in-game systems were more enjoyable when the game clearly communicated both the results and consequences of player actions so that players can learn what to do and not to do, rather than guessing what happened.

A major theme I identified throughout the responses was information overload, as more than seventy percent of participants described the passive skill tree and item modifier systems as visually overwhelming and cognitively demanding. Players noted that the abundance of information on screen required constant mental tracking and frequent reference to external resources such as wikis or build planners. These comments suggest that the interface heavily depends on player memory rather than providing intuitive, in-game cues to guide decision-making.



(image above) An empty passive skill tree. You must start from the center and branch off, and with each circle, if you hover the mouse over is a skill with sometimes up to a paragraph of text.

Another recurring issue was the lack of visual clarity during combat. Many players stated that they often died without knowing what had caused their death. The high number of overlapping particle effects, visual clutter, and limited contrast between key elements made it difficult to interpret feedback in real time. Players expressed frustration with the chaotic presentation of information and requested clearer indicators of damage, status effects, and enemy attacks.



(image above) An average encounter with 3 “rare” type enemies that have an effect that both cover the ground and explode, along with extra particles, rendering my character and other enemies almost untraceable if optional health bars were not enabled

Navigation within menus was another source of frustration. Players found that core systems such as crafting, trading, and passive skill management were spread across multiple menus or tabs, forcing them to memorize locations rather than relying on logical design cues. Many described the interface as “unnecessarily complicated,” noting that important information was not grouped intuitively. This inconsistency disrupted task flow and increased cognitive effort during basic interactions.



(image above) Currently in the "orbs" sub menu or the crafting menu, with multiple other sub menus that are related to crafting (Delerium, Essence, Socketables, and Rituals), with the item types separated by clicking arrows in the top corners. You are also required to hover your mouse over each crafting item individually to see what it does.



(images above) a continuation of the crafting menus

Participants also described heavy reliance on developer approved third party external tools, such as in-game loot filters and build planners, to make sense of the game's complex systems. While players praised the community resources, they felt that this reliance showed a lack of sufficient in-game support. Many believed that more built-in explanations, tooltips, and visual aids would reduce the need for external references.



(image above) After completing an encounter without a loot filter



(image above) The same location as the above image, but with a third-party loot filter script enabled

Takeaways

The results of this inquiry show that Path of Exile 2’s interface creates significant cognitive and perceptual strain for even its most experienced users. The game's depth and complexity are core to its identity, but the visual and informational design make it challenging to manage and navigate the game efficiently. To improve usability, the interface should externalize knowledge by adding contextual tooltips and overall clearer visual mapping to reduce reliance on players' memory. Visuals should be simplified to highlight essential information while minimizing background clutter, particularly in combat and inventory management contexts. In-game feedback should be enhanced so that players can easily understand the consequences of their actions and anticipate responses. Establishing consistent structure and terminology across menus would also make menu navigation more predictable and efficient.

Summary

This study provided valuable insight into how experienced Path of Exile 2 players engage with the game's systems. Despite their experience, many players still report issues related to information overload, inconsistent navigation, and visual clarity, with some even saying how it's similar to the first game in the series. The study highlights that the game's complexity, while engaging, introduces significant cognitive load that hinders usability. Players often experience cognitive overload even after extended gameplay, major usability challenges stem from cluttered and inconsistent design, and users expect the interface to be clear, predictable, and responsive.

Major Usage Assumptions



Assumption 1: Users Can Accurately Interpret Large Amounts of Information at Once

The current interface design appears to operate under the assumption that players can comfortably process high volumes of complex information without becoming overloaded. This is particularly evident in the passive skill tree, where dozens of nodes

with detailed descriptions are displayed simultaneously, requiring players to mentally compare statistical effects and evaluate long-range implications. The system expects players to understand specialized terminology, layered mechanics, and long-term build consequences with minimal support from the interface. While experienced ARPG players or analytically inclined individuals may be able to manage this level of information density, many others experience significant strain, hesitation, and reduced decision confidence. The fundamental design need emerging from this assumption is the incorporation of progressive disclosure and clearer organization so that players are not required to interpret sprawling data sets before they are ready or equipped to do so.

Assumption 2: Users Can Reliably Identify Critical Visual Signals During Combat

The visual structure of combat suggests that the game assumes players can quickly and accurately distinguish between background effects and meaningful telegraphs, even during chaotic encounters. Dense layers of particle effects, environmental details, and ability animations create a visually demanding environment that relies on rapid perceptual filtering. The system appears to expect players to immediately identify which visuals signal incoming damage, which cues are harmless, and which require urgent response. For many players, including both newcomers and ARPG veterans, this expectation is often unrealistic. The lack of consistent prioritization for threat indicators undermines player awareness and contributes to avoidable deaths. The clear design need is a more intentional visual hierarchy that ensures threatening actions are unmistakable, distinct from decorative effects, and supported by strong directional and auditory cues.

Assumption 3: Users Know Where to Find Features Spread Across Multiple Systems

The distribution of key systems such as crafting, gem modification, and passive management across multiple separate menus reflects an assumption that players are able to remember the locations and functions of these scattered interactions. The interface provides limited navigational support and lacks organizational cohesion, which forces players to rely on trial and error or prior knowledge to locate essential features. This issue is reinforced by inconsistent layouts and the absence of cross-linking between related systems. As a result, both new and returning players frequently open incorrect menus or forget where specific actions are stored. The design need that emerges from this assumption is a unified and predictable character management structure that consolidates related features and reduces reliance on memory.

Assumption 4: Users Understand the Consequences of Their Decisions Without Preview Information

Across several core systems, the interface appears to assume that players possess an intuitive understanding of how their choices will affect their characters or items, even when preview information is limited or nonexistent. Selecting passive nodes requires players to infer how a change will influence their build without being shown projected stat shifts or synergy effects. Crafting interactions often proceeds without outcome previews, probability indicators, or examples, yet the system still expects players to make informed decisions. This assumption creates a disadvantage for anyone who does not already have deep familiarity with the game's mechanics and discourages experimentation due to fear of irreversible mistakes. The associated design need is a strong feedforward that provides clear, actionable insight into the consequences of each decision before players commit resources.

Assumption 5: Users Can Evaluate Loot Quickly Without Prioritization Cues

The loot system appears to assume that players can rapidly analyze item value in the field without assistance from visual prioritization or modifier summarization. Items present dense, compact text that requires interpretation of technical terminology, and the interface does little to highlight attributes that matter most. As a result, players must manually scan each item and apply their own knowledge to determine relevance. This process significantly burdens new players and disrupts pacing for experienced players who prefer fluid gameplay. Without a clear visual hierarchy or grouping, item evaluation becomes slow and cognitively demanding. The design need is a more supportive loot interface that elevates key information, groups related modifiers, and allows for a glance assessment.

Assumption 6: Users Are Comfortable Finding Critical Information Through External Tools

The game design implicitly assumes that players will rely on external resources such as wikis, build planners, crafting simulators, and loot filters to fill informational gaps. Many essential mechanics and explanations are not available within the interface itself, which requires players to supplement their understanding through community-created tools. While these resources are valuable, their necessity indicates that the internal interface does not adequately communicate foundational knowledge. This assumption disadvantages new players who may not know where to find reliable resources and disrupts immersion for players who prefer to engage with systems organically. The design need is stronger in-game support for planning, comparison, and information access, so players do not need to leave the game to understand its systems.

Assumption 7: New Players Will Overcome Initial Confusion Through Persistence Alone

The onboarding process appears to assume that new players will push through early confusion without structured guidance. Complex systems such as the passive tree, crafting mechanics, and modifier interactions are presented in their full complexity from the outset, with minimal explanation or contextual support. This places the burden on players to interpret patterns independently or seek help from the community. Many new players never overcome this barrier, leading to early attrition. The design need is a more deliberate onboarding strategy that introduces complexity gradually, provides contextual tips when needed, and builds player confidence through guided learning.

Assumption 8: Users Can Manage Inventory Flow Without Efficiency Tools

The inventory system operates with the assumption that players accept frequent interruptions to reorganize items, compare gear, and make space for new drops. The grid-based structure and limited automation tools require constant micro management, which reduces gameplay momentum and adds unnecessary repetition. This expectation does not align with modern ARPG standards, where streamlined inventory processes are common. Manual sorting, repetitive evaluation of modifiers, and frequent interruptions create friction that many players find tedious. The design need is a more efficient and user-controlled inventory management experience that preserves pacing and minimizes downtime.

Violations of Universal Usability Principles

Violation 1: Excessive Cognitive Load

The current interface places a substantial cognitive burden on players by presenting large volumes of information at once without appropriate structural support. The passive skill tree is one of the most prominent examples of this issue. Players must absorb detailed text, compare multiple statistical effects, and mentally track long chain interactions while dozens of nodes remain visible at the same time. Because the system does not employ filtering, progressive disclosure, or meaningful grouping, players are required to synthesize complex information independently. This slows decision-making and contributes to fatigue during longer sessions, particularly for players who lack prior experience with similarly complex games.

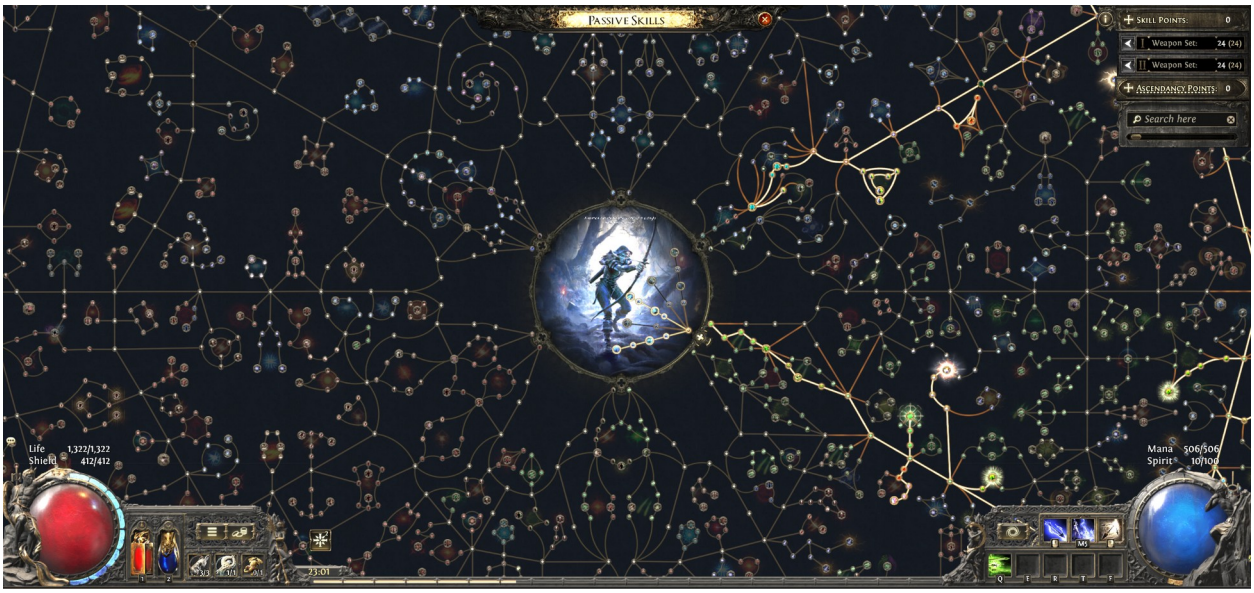


Image above showcasing the in-game skill tree

A related issue emerges within the item modifier system. Many items contain long lists of small text modifiers that players must interpret manually. Players reported repeatedly having to recall what each modifier means, which versions are valuable, and how the modifiers interact with their builds. Without summarization or clear grouping, the system places unnecessary reliance on memory. Over time, this repeated interpretive effort compounds and leads to frustration, especially during extended play sessions.



For each of the underlined stats, the player must open their inventory, hold left alt, and then hover their mouse over them to read the exact specifics of what it does, how to trigger it, and how their other stats affect it

Violation 2: Poor Visibility of System Status

Players consistently expressed that the interface does not provide clear visibility into critical game states during fast-paced combat. Many reported dying without understanding the source of the damage. Enemy attacks, projectiles, and ground effects often blend into surrounding particle effects, making them difficult to distinguish from non-threatening visuals. Without strong visual or auditory indicators that draw attention to meaningful threats, players cannot reliably assess danger or react in time. This contributes to an experience that feels unpredictable and, at times, unfair.

The visibility of status conditions also presents significant challenges. Debuffs, afflictions, and damage over time effects are not consistently communicated through clear icons or animations. Some of the most punishing attacks fail to present noticeable indicators, leaving players unaware that their character is being affected. When the system does not visibly communicate its current state, players struggle to understand what is happening and cannot adjust their actions effectively.



Image above showcasing poor visual clarity during combat while in endgame content

Violation 3: Inefficient and Unpredictable Mapping

The organization of key features across multiple interfaces creates unpredictable navigation patterns that slow down routine tasks. Crafting is one of the clearest examples. Options related to crafting are distributed across several separate systems, including crafting benches, NPC services, socketing interfaces, and specialized crafting windows. Because these functions are not consolidated or consistently structured, players must remember where each type of action resides instead of accessing them through a unified, intuitive grouping.

Gem and skill management exhibit similar issues. Socketing, upgrading, adjusting support gems, and managing active skills take place across multiple windows that do not share consistent layouts or interaction logic. Players reported frequently forgetting where specific actions were located because the interface lacked cohesive structure. These inconsistencies force players to search through menus and increase the time required to complete tasks that should be simple and routine.



Images above showcasing two of the nine different crafting menu tabs in the game, all with items that may look similar to one another in color, but have entirely different effects on an item

Violation 4: Insufficient Support for Recognition

The interface regularly requires players to recall information rather than recognizing it from context, which increases cognitive effort and the likelihood of errors. Modifier terminology is a notable contributor to this issue. Many item modifiers use specialized or ambiguous wording that the interface does not clearly define. Without immediate explanations or visual grouping, players must memorize these terms or look them up externally each time they appear. This reliance on recall slows item evaluation and diminishes confidence in decision-making.

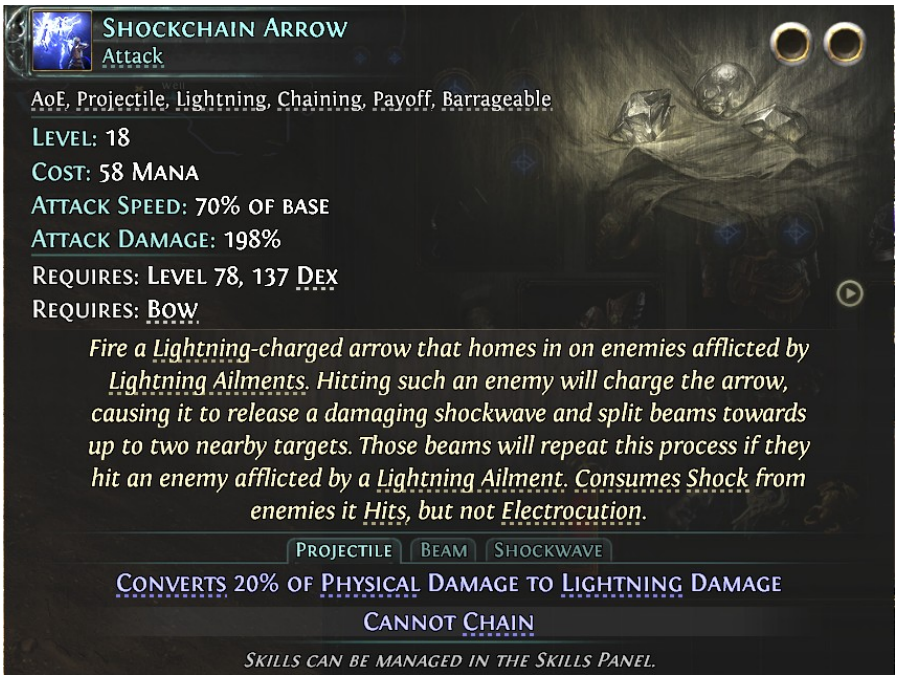


Image above showing one of the skills in the game, each of the underlined words in the skill description requires the player to hold Alt and hover the mouse over to reveal another paragraph describing what it does

Crafting outcomes further illustrates this problem. Players often reported uncertainty about what a crafting action would produce before confirming it. Many actions lack descriptions, previews, or explicit explanations, which forces players to rely on prior experience or third-party guides. When recognition is not supported, players become hesitant to experiment and avoid systems that appear unpredictable or confusing.

Violation 5: Lack of Clear Visual Hierarchy

The interface does not consistently differentiate between high priority and low priority information, which impedes player awareness and slows reaction time. During combat, heavy particle effects and overlapping visuals obscure crucial cues such as enemy attacks or ground hazards. Players frequently described needing to scan the entire screen to identify threats because nothing visually commands attention. Without clear emphasis, players cannot efficiently determine where to focus their attention, and avoidable damage becomes more common.



Both the bright blue and orange abilities being used are generated from the player, the actual environmental hazards are the dark orange rings, partially clipping into the ground, that are capable of killing the player in a single hit

Menu interfaces suffer from the same issue. Inventory and crafting screens contain dense concentrations of icons, modifiers, and small text without sufficient spacing or contrast. Because everything appears visually similar, players must spend additional time searching for important information such as rare item indicators or key crafting ingredients. Weak hierarchy reduces efficiency, increases cognitive load, and contributes to errors.

Violation 6: Limited Feedforward

Players frequently indicated that the interface does not communicate the outcomes of their actions before they commit to them. In the passive skill tree, players sometimes select nodes without understanding how the change will influence their build. The interface does not always present forward-looking information that helps players anticipate whether the node will meaningfully support their goals. This uncertainty reduces willingness to experiment and increases the risk of wasted resources.

Crafting systems present similar challenges. Many crafting actions do not show previews, probabilities, or clear descriptions, leaving players unsure whether their action will improve the item or introduce undesirable outcomes. Since crafting consumes

valuable currency, players hesitate to engage with the system when feedback is unclear. The absence of feedforward erodes confidence and discourages participation in a core game mechanic.

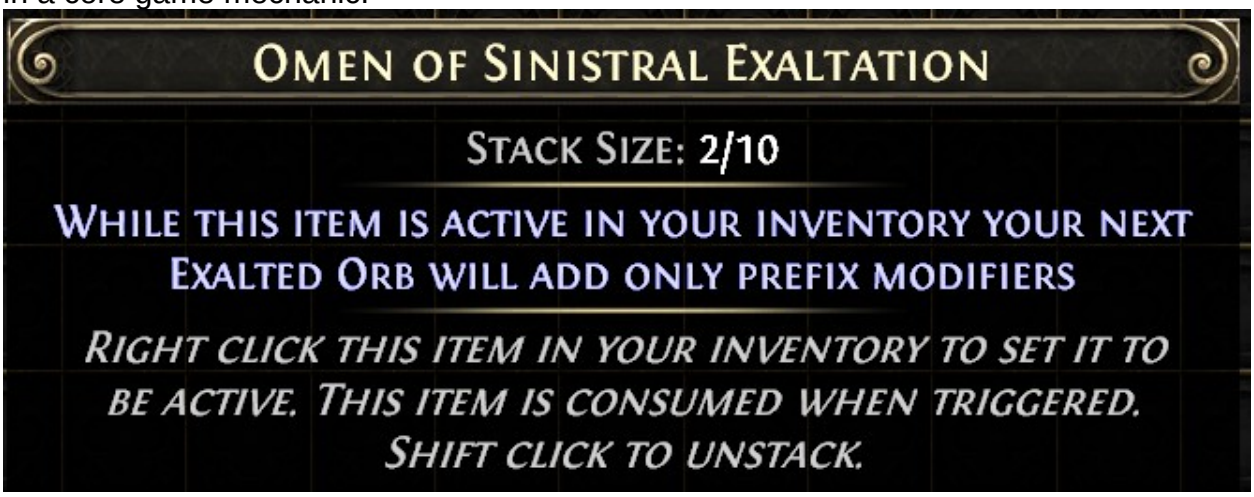


Image above showing that while the item will provide a prefix modifier, there is no list in-game to actually view what prefix modifiers are

Violation 7: High Dependency on External Resources

Many players indicated that the interface provides insufficient internal support for understanding core systems, resulting in heavy reliance on external tools. Build planning is one of the most prominent examples. Because the passive skill tree lacks long-term planning tools or visualization options, players must use third-party planners to map out builds. When a central game feature requires outside resources to function effectively, it signals a significant usability issue within the system itself.

The same pattern appears in loot evaluation. The default item display presents too much clutter and does not offer filtering tools to highlight valuable drops. As a result, third-party loot filters become essential for identifying meaningful items and managing cognitive load. This dependence underscores a gap in the internal interface, which should allow players to assess item value efficiently without external assistance.



Image above showing a commonly used loot filter by the community and the multiple levels of filter intensity that needed to be created as you progress the game

Interface-Based Usability Problems and Suggested Solutions

Overwhelming Information Density in the Passive Skill Tree

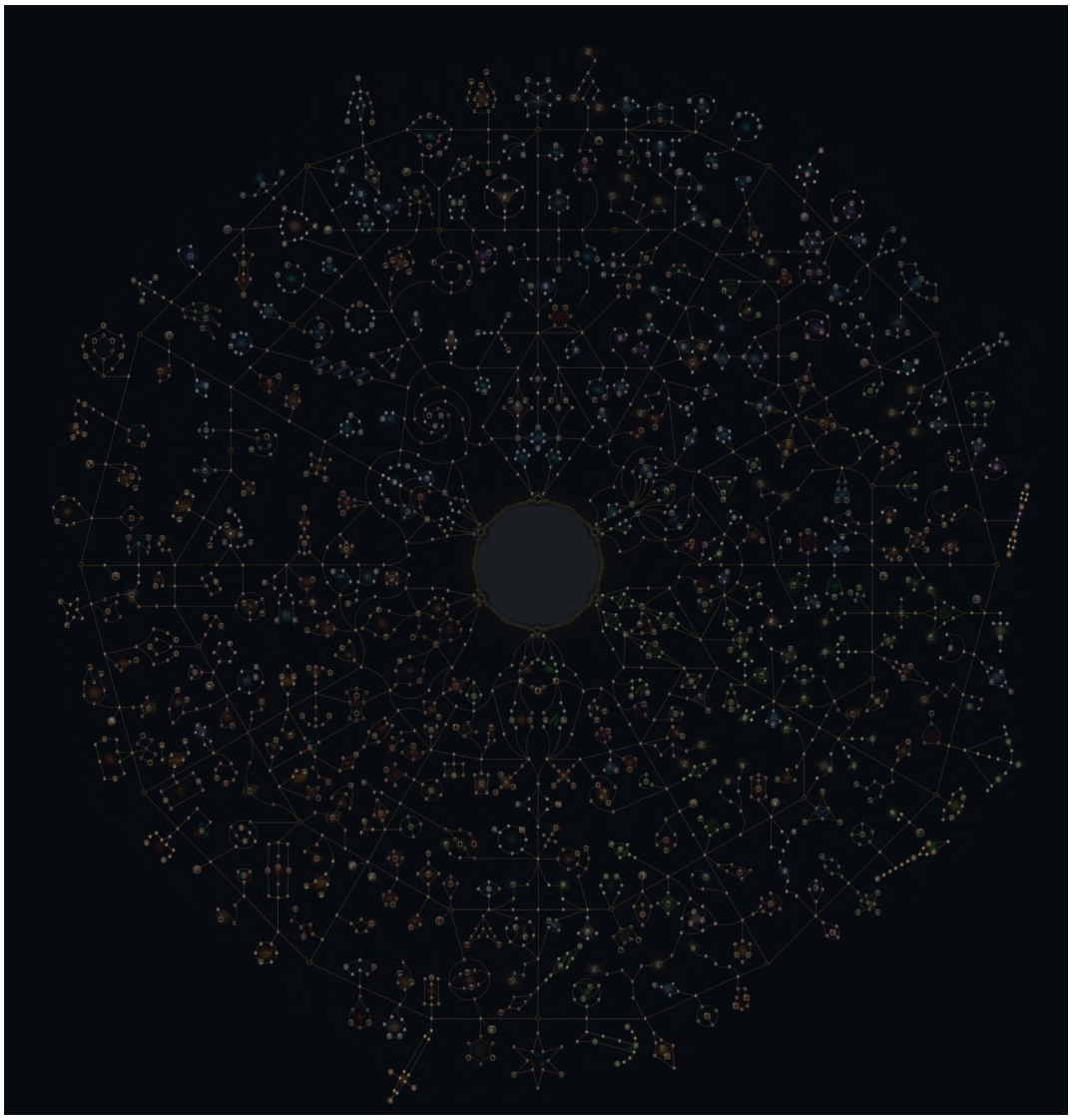
The passive skill tree presents substantially more information than most players can reasonably process at one time. Survey responses consistently described feelings of overload when attempting to evaluate clusters of nodes, largely because the interface displays every option simultaneously without meaningful organization. The dense text, small font size, and lack of progressive disclosure force players to stop repeatedly and manually inspect individual nodes. This significantly slows down decision-making and disrupts the natural rhythm of gameplay, especially for players who are unfamiliar with complex RPG systems.

A second issue is the absence of clear categorization. Nodes with similar functions do not stand out visually, and clusters lack labels that help players understand their

broader purpose. Many players reported having to hover over every node in a cluster simply to understand which ones provided offensive benefits and which ones provided defensive or utility benefits. This creates unnecessary friction for new players and adds decision fatigue for experienced players who prefer to spend their time refining builds rather than parsing text.

Suggested Solutions:

The passive skill tree should incorporate collapsible clusters that expand only when selected, reducing the initial information load and helping players focus on smaller, more manageable decision sets. Visual coding techniques such as color themes, iconography, or consistent category labels would further help players identify related nodes quickly. A search feature that highlights relevant nodes or pathways would reduce cognitive effort and support more efficient planning.



The image above shows how the skill tree is at present. Every small dot represents a different skill. Players always start from the center and need to branch out

Poor Combat Readability and Damage Feedback

Players consistently reported that combat encounters lacked clear and reliable visual communication. A primary concern was that enemy attacks frequently blended into surrounding particle effects and environmental details, which made it difficult to recognize threats in real time. When harmful effects do not stand out from visually busy backgrounds, players cannot react appropriately, and the resulting deaths feel sudden and avoidable. This undermines player confidence and reduces overall enjoyment.

A second issue is the lack of distinction between routine animations and dangerous mechanics. Many players stated that high-damage attacks from bosses or elite enemies looked too similar to normal movement or non-threatening abilities. Without clear cues indicating when a powerful attack is being prepared, players cannot anticipate incoming hazards or make informed defensive decisions.

Suggested Solutions:
Combat readability would be significantly improved by strengthening the contrast and clarity of critical enemy attacks. Standardizing visual markers for major abilities, introducing clearer outlines, or reinforcing danger cues with consistent color patterns would help players recognize threats more quickly. Adding directional indicators or distinct impact feedback would further reinforce awareness and support more reactive and informed gameplay.



Image above shows poor visual clarity during combat, there is both a boss and a player character in this frame

Fragmented Navigation Across Core Menus

Players frequently reported difficulty navigating key systems because related functions were spread across multiple menus with little cohesion. Crafting is a primary example. Features associated with crafting appear in several different locations, such as individual crafting benches, multiple NPC services, and specialized crafting windows. Because these interactions are scattered, players must remember where each function is located, which disrupts efficiency and introduces unnecessary complexity into routine tasks.

Gem and skill management follow a similar pattern. Socketing, linking, leveling, and modifying skills occur across different menus that do not share consistent structures or visual patterns. Players often open the wrong menu or navigate in circles because the system does not clearly communicate where a particular action should occur. This fragmentation undermines usability and discourages players from experimenting with builds or mechanics.

Suggested Solutions:
Usability would be greatly improved by consolidating these systems into a unified character management interface. Centralizing passive skills, crafting, gem modification, and equipment interactions into a single multi-tab window would reduce redundant navigation steps and create a more intuitive structure. Implementing consistent layouts and cross-linking between related functions would further streamline the experience and support both new and experienced players.

Lack of Clear Explanations for Modifiers and Crafting Outcomes

Many players struggled to interpret item modifiers because the interface offered limited explanations and lacked contextual clarity. Modifiers often use terminology that is unfamiliar or ambiguous, and players must guess how a modifier affects performance or interacts with other mechanics. This slows down loot evaluation and increases the risk of making poor decisions, such as discarding valuable items or keeping items that are ineffective.

Crafting presents a similar challenge. Players frequently reported that crafting actions did not clearly communicate their outcomes. Without previews or supporting detail, players were hesitant to use expensive resources, as they could not predict whether a crafting action would improve an item or introduce unwanted changes. This uncertainty discourages engagement with a system that should be exciting and rewarding.

Suggested Solutions:
Item modifiers should include expanded tooltips that provide clear definitions and examples illustrating how each modifier functions in practice. Crafting interfaces should present preview windows or probability ranges that help players anticipate potential results. A guided crafting mode would give new users step-by-step support while still allowing advanced users to bypass tutorials once they are comfortable.

Ineffective Visual Hierarchy in Inventory and Menus

Inventory and menu interfaces contain dense clusters of icons and text but offer few cues to guide attention toward important information. Players frequently described struggling to identify valuable drops because rare items did not consistently stand out from common ones. The lack of prioritization forces players to scan items slowly and methodically, which disrupts gameplay pacing and increases cognitive effort.

Crafting menus suffers from similar hierarchy issues. High-value upgrades and essential recipes are often presented in the same visual style as less important options. Without visual emphasis, players must manually review each entry, which slows down interaction and discourages experimentation.

Suggested Solutions:
The interface would benefit from clearer spacing, stronger color differentiation, and increased text contrast for high-priority information. Rare items, important modifiers, and essential crafting options should be visually distinct. Adjustments in scale, placement, or color treatment can support faster recognition and more confident decision-making.

Limited Feedforward for Major Gameplay Decisions

Players often lacked the information needed to anticipate the outcomes of their decisions. In the passive skill tree, many nodes did not clearly indicate how they would affect player stats or abilities once selected. This absence of predictive guidance caused players to hesitate, as they did not want to spend resources on choices that might not benefit their builds.

Crafting also showed significant feedforward gaps. Players often interacted with crafting options without understanding which modifiers would be added, removed, or altered. Since crafting materials are valuable, this uncertainty discouraged players from fully engaging with the system.

Suggested Solutions:
A live preview system for passive nodes would allow players to see projected stat changes before committing. Crafting interfaces should offer detailed breakdowns of possible outcomes or summarized previews showing likely results. Interactive mock previews would reduce uncertainty and encourage more confident decision-making.

Heavy Dependence on External Tools

A significant number of players reported turning to external tools because the in-game interface did not support essential planning or evaluation tasks. Build planners were used extensively because the passive skill tree lacked tools for long-term visualization or path exploration. Players found themselves switching between the game and third-party websites simply to make informed decisions about their characters.

Loot evaluation required similar external support. The default item display presents too many items at once and lacks filtering options, which leads players to rely on third-party loot filters to reduce clutter and identify valuable gear. This reliance indicates that core usability functions are absent from the internal interface.

Suggested Solutions:
Integrating a built-in build planner that allows for path projection and future planning would eliminate the need for external planning tools. A customizable in-game loot filter system would allow players to define visibility rules and highlight priorities without depending on third-party solutions. This would improve usability, preserve immersion, and support a wider range of player preferences.



Image above showing how the game looks without a loot filter after completing a dungeon in the late game

Goal-Based Usability Problems and Suggested Solutions

Difficulty Achieving the Goal of Efficient Build Optimization

Players consistently identified build optimization as a central objective, yet the current interface presents significant barriers to achieving this goal. The passive skill tree demands that players visualize long-term development across an extremely large set of options without any system support for planning, comparing, or experimenting. Because the interface does not allow users to preview hypothetical allocations or save alternate routes, players must mentally track distant nodes and remember potential paths over time. This makes long-term planning both cognitively demanding and error-prone.

Compounding the issue, the interface does not provide tools for side-by-side comparisons of builds or configurations. Players who want to test variations must commit resources blindly or rely on external build planners to perform what should be a native in-game function. This breaks immersion and reinforces the perception that the game lacks internal support for a core progression workflow. The absence of planning tools undermines one of the most important player goals and forces reliance on methods outside the intended user experience.

Suggested Solution:
A dedicated planning mode within the passive skill tree would allow players to preview potential allocations, experiment freely, and compare multiple build paths without spending currency. Displaying projected stat changes and visually highlighting archetype routes would help players make informed decisions. Allowing users to save and switch between build drafts would further streamline the process and reduce dependence on third-party planners.

Difficulty Meeting the Goal of Understanding Combat Situations

Players emphasized the importance of maintaining situational awareness during combat, yet many reported that understanding what occurs in real time is one of the most challenging aspects of Path of Exile 2. Users frequently described deaths that felt sudden or inexplicable because the sources of damage were visually obscured by particle effects, environmental noise, or overlapping animations. When critical cues blend into the background, players cannot identify threats quickly enough to react, which reduces the sense of fairness and prevents meaningful learning.

This issue becomes even more severe during boss encounters. High damage attacks often resemble routine animations, making it difficult for players to anticipate danger or recognize when evasive action is required. Without clear differentiation between lethal threats and ordinary movements, players cannot accurately interpret the flow of combat. These gaps in visual communication directly undermine the goal of understanding combat situations and diminish player confidence.

Suggested Solution:
Enhancing visual and auditory cues for dangerous events would significantly improve situational awareness. Stronger contrast for high-impact attacks, standardized telegraph animations, and distinct warning indicators would allow players to identify hazards more reliably. Directional damage indicators and simplified particle effects during critical moments would further support rapid interpretation and informed decision-making.

Inability to Reach the Goal of Navigating Core Systems Efficiently

Many players expressed that they want to access and manage core gameplay systems quickly, but the fragmented structure of the interface makes this difficult. Crafting functionality is distributed across multiple benches, NPC menus, and specialized windows that do not share a cohesive structure. Users must remember which location supports which crafting action, which introduces unnecessary cognitive load and slows down routine tasks.

Gem and skill management present similar challenges. Socketing, linking, upgrading, and modifying gems occur across different menus with inconsistent visual patterns. Players often open the wrong interface or navigate repeatedly between menus in search of the option they need. This disrupts workflow and makes actions that should be simple feel cumbersome. The absence of a predictable structure prevents players from efficiently achieving the goal of navigating core systems.

Suggested Solution:
Creating a unified character management interface with clearly labeled tabs would consolidate related functions into a single, intuitive structure. Consistent layouts across tabs and cross navigation between interconnected features would reduce confusion and streamline the user's workflow. Centralizing these systems would support faster and more efficient interactions for both new and experienced players.

Difficulty Meeting the Goal of Understanding Item Value and Crafting Decisions

Players consistently stated that they want to make informed decisions about gear and crafting, yet the interface does not provide the clarity needed to evaluate item value confidently. Many item modifiers use terminology that is difficult to interpret, and the absence of clear explanations forces players to rely on memory or external sources. This slows down gameplay and makes the loot evaluation process feel tedious rather than rewarding.

Crafting systems exacerbate this issue. Players often described interacting with crafting options without understanding what the result would be. Because many features lack previews or detailed explanations, users hesitate to spend valuable resources on actions that may produce unwanted outcomes. This uncertainty interferes with the goal of making confident decisions and discourages engagement with a system that is intended to be exciting and empowering.

Suggested Solution:
Item tooltips should include clearer explanations and short examples illustrating how modifiers affect gameplay. Crafting interfaces should present preview windows, outcome summaries, or probability ranges to help players understand likely results. These additions would support more confident decision-making and reduce reliance on external sources.

Difficulty Achieving the Goal of Quickly Identifying Valuable Loot

Players want to remain immersed in fast-paced gameplay, yet the default item display makes identifying valuable loot a slow and effortful process. The system presents a large number of items at once with minimal differentiation between high-value and low-value drops. As a result, players must manually examine each item in visually cluttered environments, which interrupts the rhythm of exploration and combat. This is especially taxing since many modifiers require technical knowledge to interpret.

Players who want to achieve the goal of quickly recognizing meaningful loot cannot do so effectively with the current level of visual clarity. Many players resort to external loot filters because the in-game interface does not support their needs. This reliance underscores a gap in the internal design and contributes to unnecessary friction.

Suggested Solution:
Introducing a customizable in-game loot filtering system would allow players to hide unimportant items and highlight gear relevant to their build. Enhancing tooltip formatting with clearer grouping, priority indicators, or improved contrast would help users identify valuable items at a glance. These improvements would significantly increase efficiency and maintain gameplay momentum.

Difficulty Meeting the Goal of Managing Inventory Smoothly

Inventory management is a frequent and essential player task, yet many users described it as labor-intensive and disruptive. The grid-based inventory system requires continual rearranging because item sizes vary and lack grouping that would simplify organization. This repetitive sorting interrupts gameplay flow and adds friction that detracts from the overall experience.

Comparing items also imposes additional effort. The interface does not consistently highlight key differences or summarize improvements, which forces players to scan small text or hover repeatedly between items. This slows down decision-making and makes inventory management feel more tedious than necessary.

Suggested Solution:
Adding an auto-sort function, dedicated storage for crafting materials, and clear visual grouping for item categories would significantly streamline inventory management. Enhanced comparison tools that highlight stat changes or summarize improvements would allow users to evaluate gear more quickly without breaking gameplay flow.

Difficulty Achieving the Goal of Continuous, Uninterrupted Gameplay

Players want to maintain immersion and avoid interruptions, yet many reported frequently leaving the game to look up essential information. Build planning, item evaluation, and crafting decisions often require third-party tools because the in-game interface does not provide the necessary depth, clarity, or long-term planning capabilities. This reliance breaks the user's momentum and fragments the overall experience.

Players turn to external build planners because the passive skill tree does not support long-term visualization or configurable planning. They consult external resources for crafting knowledge because the interface does not present probability details or expected outcomes. They use third-party databases to evaluate item value because in-game explanations are limited. These gaps prevent players from achieving the goal of uninterrupted gameplay.

Suggested Solution:
Integrating a build planner, searchable knowledge panels, and a richer item database directly into the interface would greatly reduce reliance on external tools. Adding in-game stat projections, crafting guides, and contextual help would support uninterrupted gameplay while still preserving depth for experienced users.

Final Conclusion and Disposition



The overall evaluation of Path of Exile 2 demonstrates that the game is built upon a remarkably strong design foundation. Its depth, mechanical sophistication, and long-term engagement potential set it apart within the action RPG genre. These qualities position the game to offer a rich and rewarding experience for a wide range of players. However, the assessment also shows that the current interface introduces significant usability challenges that hinder players' ability to fully access and appreciate that depth. Core systems such as the passive skill tree, crafting, inventory management, and combat readability impose cognitive barriers that make routine tasks more demanding than necessary. Players are frequently required to interpret dense information, search across fragmented menus, and make consequential decisions without adequate support or predictive feedback. These factors directly influence players' speed, confidence, and clarity when pursuing their goals, which ultimately shape their satisfaction and reduce the likelihood of long-term engagement.

Despite these concerns, the issues identified throughout the evaluation are both manageable and addressable through targeted improvements. The recommendations provided do not call for reducing complexity or simplifying core mechanics. Instead, they focus on strengthening communication, improving information structure, and supporting the workflows that players already value. Enhancing the clarity of visual cues, consolidating related systems into unified interfaces, improving modifier and crafting explanations, and integrating essential planning tools will reduce friction without compromising the strategic depth that defines Path of Exile's identity. These refinements would help players understand the systems more intuitively, make decisions more confidently, and stay engaged for longer periods of time.

Based on the analysis conducted, the disposition of this evaluation is that Path of Exile 2 stands on an exceptional foundation but would benefit significantly from usability enhancements that better support player comprehension and decision-making. The game's most compelling qualities remain intact, yet their impact is limited by presentation and workflow issues that obscure the richness of the underlying systems. Implementing the recommended improvements would elevate the user experience, strengthen the game's approachability, and increase long-term retention by offering clearer guidance, more intuitive progression pathways, and more supportive tools for experimentation. Path of Exile 2 has the potential to deliver a deeply rewarding experience for both new and returning players. With thoughtful refinement, it can become more welcoming, more intuitive, and ultimately more satisfying for the broad and diverse audience that the game continues to attract.



Personas and Grades

Persona 1: Elias Chen, The Strategic Planner



Description:
Elias is a thoughtful and analytical player who approaches Path of Exile 2 with a strong desire to understand systems in depth. He is fascinated by the intricacy of build creation and consistently invests time exploring how passive nodes, skill gems, item modifiers, and crafting methods interact. Elias often creates multiple characters to test archetypes and refine long-term strategies. His satisfaction comes from mastery and precision rather than speed, and he values interfaces that support structured thinking. While he embraces complexity, he expects the interface to help him analyze information rather than forcing him to search for scattered details.

Primary Goals:
Elias wants to make confident long-term decisions by understanding how routes, item combinations, and crafting actions influence the direction of his build. He values strong forecasting tools, clear information design, and the ability to experiment safely before committing resources.

Business Value:
Strategic Planners like Elias add depth to the game's ecosystem by producing guides, theorycrafting content, and consistent seasonal engagement. They help shape the meta, influence community behavior, and encourage long-term retention within the player base.

Grade: C
Rationale:
The current interface does not fully support the level of planning Elias needs. The passive skill tree lacks tools for previewing future routes, crafting systems do not provide predictive guidance, and inventory comparisons require manual effort. Although the depth he enjoys is present, the interface does not help him interpret or manage that depth efficiently.

Persona 2: Maya Rodriguez, The Action Focused Combatant



Description:
Maya plays Path of Exile 2 for its fast-paced combat and enjoys the intensity of moment-to-moment decision-making. She values responsiveness, clarity, and well-timed cues that allow her to react skillfully. Maya does not spend significant time planning builds or studying modifiers. Instead, she relies on the interface to communicate threats clearly and consistently. She becomes frustrated when unclear visuals, particle clutter, or unpredictable telegraphs interrupt the flow of combat or make deaths feel unavoidable.

Primary Goals:
Maya wants immediate awareness of incoming attacks, predictable cues for enemy abilities, and reliable feedback that allows her to maintain control during high-pressure encounters.

Business Value:
Action-focused players like Maya represent a large portion of the active player base. They sustain daily engagement across mapping, bossing, and league progression, and their activity helps maintain the momentum of seasonal cycles.

Grade: C minus
Rationale:
Maya's goals are hindered by unclear combat readability. Important attacks blend into effects, telegraphs lack consistency, and damage often appears without a clear indication. These issues disrupt her preferred gameplay rhythm. Additional friction, such as inventory interruptions and unclear loot presentation, further disrupts her flow.

Persona 3: Samir Patel, The Efficient Collector



Description:
Samir finds enjoyment in the looting and inventory systems that define the ARPG genre. He appreciates rapid movement through maps, large quantities of drops, and the satisfaction of evaluating items quickly and efficiently. Samir values interfaces that present information clearly so he can maintain momentum without frequent pauses. He becomes frustrated when systems demand repetitive reading, constant rearrangement, or manual interpretation of dense text.

Primary Goals:
Samir wants to identify valuable items at a glance, compare gear quickly, maintain an orderly inventory, and craft items confidently and efficiently.

Business Value:
Efficient Collectors like Samir drive the in-game economy by engaging deeply with crafting, trading, and mapping. Their activity supports item circulation and contributes significantly to the health and progression of seasonal environments.

Grade: D plus
Rationale:
Samir's goals face significant obstacles in the current interface. Loot lacks clear prioritization, modifiers are difficult to parse quickly, and the inventory grid requires constant manual sorting. Crafting outcomes are unclear, which disrupts his efficiency and workflow. These issues interfere directly with the activities he values most, resulting in one of the lowest persona grades.

Persona 4: Marcus Hale, The Experienced Veteran



Description:
Marcus is an experienced Path of Exile player with a deep understanding of systems, mechanics, and endgame content. He is comfortable with complex itemization, advanced crafting methods, and high-tier combat. Marcus expects the interface to support his expertise by reducing unnecessary steps and providing clear, efficient communication. He notices subtle inefficiencies that may go unnoticed by newer players and values precision in both combat and system navigation.

Primary Goals:
Marcus wants to progress efficiently, evaluate items at high speed, engage confidently with crafting, and maintain awareness during intense combat. He relies on clarity, consistency, and tools that elevate advanced play.

Business Value:
Experienced Veterans like Marcus are extremely valuable to the community. They anchor the endgame, produce high level strategies, mentor newer players, and fuel ongoing meta development. Their retention is central to long term game health.

Grade: B minus
Rationale:
Marcus can compensate for many usability shortcomings due to his experience, yet he is still slowed by unclear combat readability, visual clutter, and insufficient crafting feedback. These issues reduce his efficiency and disrupt high-level gameplay, resulting in a moderate grade despite his expertise.

Persona 5: Ava Thompson, The New Adventurer



Description:
Ava is new to Path of Exile and has been drawn in by the excitement surrounding its release. With limited experience in the genre, she relies heavily on the interface to guide her through unfamiliar systems. She enters the game with curiosity and enthusiasm, but becomes overwhelmed when complex information is presented without structure or explanation. Ava needs approachable onboarding, clear communication, and gradual introduction to deep mechanics so she can build confidence.

Primary Goals:
Ava wants to learn the basics of skills, items, and passive choices without confusion. She aims to understand what loot is valuable, how to manage her inventory, and how to survive early encounters. Her goals depend on clear guidance and structured learning.

Business Value:
New Adventurers like Ava are essential for expanding the player base. They bring new energy to seasonal cycles, create fresh demand for content, and can become loyal long-term players if their initial experience is welcoming and intuitive.

Grade: D
Rationale:
Ava faces the steepest learning curve due to unclear onboarding and dense early information. The passive tree feels overwhelming, item modifiers are difficult to interpret, and crafting is not clearly explained. Combat readability challenges further disrupt her ability to learn through experience. These barriers reduce early confidence and risk discouraging long-term engagement.

Checklist of Issues and Recommendations



Information Density and Overload

A significant usability challenge across the interface is the volume and density of information presented at once, which places unnecessary cognitive strain on players. The passive skill tree is the most pronounced example. It displays an extensive network of nodes simultaneously without filtering, progressive disclosure, or meaningful structural guidance. Players frequently reported that they were forced to inspect nodes individually because the interface provided no support for scanning or recognizing patterns. This slows decision-making, disrupts flow, and creates fatigue during longer sessions.

Item modifiers introduce similar challenges. Many items contain long chains of text, layered terminology, and conditional effects that require repeated interpretation. New players struggle to understand basic meaning, while experienced players become burdened by the amount of repetitive reading required during high-volume loot evaluation. These issues can be alleviated through a more structured information hierarchy that introduces detail gradually, improves scanning efficiency, and gives players greater control over how much information they view at any given moment.

Recommendation for future improvement:
Implement progressive disclosure, clearer grouping of related data, improved visual hierarchy, and optional detail expansion features that reduce cognitive load.

Combat Readability Problems

Combat readability remains one of the most critical usability issues affecting all player personas. Heavy particle effects frequently obscure enemy attacks, projectiles, and environmental hazards, making it difficult for players to distinguish between decorative visuals and meaningful threats. Many described sudden deaths that occurred with little to no warning, which undermines fairness and erodes trust in the system.

The boss further compounds this issue. High damage abilities often resemble routine animations because the telegraphs lack distinct markers or timing cues. When players cannot reliably detect or anticipate danger, combat becomes unpredictable rather than skill-based. Improving readability is essential not only for fairness but also for maintaining engagement during high-intensity encounters.

Recommendation for future improvement:
Increase visual contrast for dangerous attacks, reinforce telegraphs with standardized animations and audio cues, and simplify visual effects during critical combat moments to ensure that threats are clearly distinguishable.

Fragmented Navigation Across Core Systems

The interface spreads key functionality across multiple menus and locations, creating friction whenever players attempt to modify items, adjust skills, or manage character progression. Crafting is heavily fragmented, requiring players to navigate between benches, NPCs, and specialized menus depending on the action they intend to perform. This makes the system difficult to learn and frustrating to use during routine gameplay.

Skill gem management presents similar fragmentation. Socketing, linking, upgrading, and modifying gems occur in separate interfaces that lack visual consistency or intuitive structure. Players often reported opening the wrong windows or navigating in loops because related actions are not grouped logically. Even experienced players described this workflow as inefficient.

Recommendation for future improvement:
Develop a unified, tab-based character management interface that consolidates crafting, gem management, passive skill adjustments, and equipment modifications into a cohesive structure with predictable navigation.

Unclear Crafting Outcomes

Crafting systems frequently fail to provide the clarity needed for informed decision-making. Many actions lack previews or detailed descriptions, leaving players uncertain about how their item will change after applying a modification. Players described hesitating to craft due to fear of wasting valuable materials or unintentionally degrading their items. Even those familiar with crafting mechanics often referenced external resources to confirm basic information.

This absence of transparent outcomes discourages experimentation and makes crafting feel risky and unintuitive. When the system cannot communicate potential results clearly, players do not feel confident engaging with one of the game's most important progression paths.

Recommendation for future improvement:
Introduce visible previews, contextual explanations, sample outcomes, and probability ranges for crafting actions to support informed and confident decision making.

Weak Visual Hierarchy in Loot and Inventory

Loot and inventory interfaces lack a strong visual hierarchy, making it difficult for players to identify valuable items quickly. Rarity, modifiers, and key attributes often fail to stand out from less important information. As a result, players must manually inspect each drop, which interrupts gameplay and increases cognitive effort. Dense text formatting and inconsistent grouping further contribute to slow evaluation.

The inventory grid amplifies this friction. Items of varying sizes require frequent rearrangement, which disrupts engagement and adds unnecessary repetition. Without clearer visual signals, the system does not support efficient gameplay loops that rely on rapid looting and seamless transitions into the next encounter.

Recommendation for future improvement:
Strengthen rarity indicators, improve modifier grouping, enhance tooltip formatting, and increase visual differentiation to improve a glance item evaluation.

Limited Predictive Feedback for Key Decisions

Many core systems do not provide predictive feedback, forcing users to make decisions without understanding their consequences. In the passive skill tree, nodes do not always display projected stat changes or interactions, which leads to uncertainty about whether a choice will benefit the player's build. Crafting systems suffer from the same issue, providing little insight into how an item will be altered before resources are spent.

Players consistently expressed frustration with unexpected outcomes and the lack of transparency surrounding consequential choices. When predictive information is limited, the sense of control diminishes, and users become more hesitant to engage with deep systems.

Recommendation for future improvement:
Introduce projected stat overlays, temporary preview states, and clear descriptions of potential outcomes to reinforce confidence and support informed decision making.

Heavy Reliance on External Tools

Players frequently rely on external tools to fill gaps in the in-game interface. Build planners are used to explore passive tree routes or test hypothetical builds because the game does not support long-term planning. Loot filters are downloaded to manage item clutter and highlight valuable drops. External databases and wikis are used to interpret modifiers, crafting outcomes, or skill interactions.

This constant switching between the game and third-party resources disrupts gameplay and highlights shortcomings in the system's ability to support essential tasks. When users must leave the game to perform routine functions, engagement and immersion suffer.

Recommendation for future improvement:
Integrate build planning tools, customizable loot filtering, expanded informational databases, and contextual help systems directly into the game to support a seamless user experience.

High Learning Curve for New Players

New players encounter a steep learning curve due to the density and complexity of information presented early in the game. The passive skill tree appears overwhelming from the start, offering little explanation of how to interpret clusters or understand keystone significance. Item modifiers rely on terminology that is difficult to decode, even for players with genre experience. Crafting introduces advanced mechanics before users have mastered foundational concepts.

These challenges create early barriers to entry and increase the likelihood that new players disengage before recognizing the depth and potential of the game. A more structured onboarding experience would significantly improve accessibility.

Recommendation for future improvement:
Implement progressive onboarding, simplified early tooltips, guided tutorials, and staged introduction of complex systems to support early understanding and reduce new player attrition.

Slow and Disruptive Inventory Workflow

Inventory management often interrupts gameplay due to frequent manual sorting, repetitive comparisons, and limited organizational tools. Players must constantly rearrange items to make space, which slows momentum and adds unnecessary downtime. Modifier text is not grouped or prioritized, which forces players to hover between comparisons or re-read dense descriptions to identify upgrades.

These issues affect all personas and consistently disrupt the core loop of combat, looting, and progression.

Recommendation for future improvement:
Add auto sorting features, clearer modifier organization, dedicated storage for crafting components, and enhanced comparison tools to streamline inventory interactions and maintain gameplay flow.

Inconsistent System Communication

Information across the interface lacks consistency in terminology, structure, and presentation. Similar concepts appear in different formats across items, skills, crafting interfaces, and passive nodes. This inconsistency increases cognitive load because players must continually adjust to new patterns instead of leveraging familiar structures.

Even experienced players reported friction when navigating between systems because each one communicated information differently. Standardization would reduce confusion and improve the overall coherence of the user experience.

Recommendation for future improvement:
Adopt consistent terminology, unify tooltip structures, and align interaction patterns across all major systems to create a predictable and intuitive interface.

Next Steps and Recommendations for Development



Refine Information Architecture to Reduce Cognitive Load

A key priority for development should be a comprehensive restructuring of how information is presented across the passive skill tree, item tooltips, and crafting interfaces. Many of the usability issues identified in this evaluation originate from the interface asking players to interpret large amounts of detailed information without adequate hierarchy or organization. The passive skill tree currently displays numerous nodes simultaneously, each containing dense text that requires deliberate reading before a player can make a meaningful choice. Repetition of this process across hundreds of potential allocations leads to fatigue and discourages experimentation.

To address this, the development team should introduce progressive disclosure techniques that allow players to reveal complexity only when they choose to engage with it. Collapsible clusters, simplified node summaries, and consistent categorization of node types would significantly reduce cognitive load. Item tooltips would also benefit from structured grouping that separates offensive, defensive, and utility modifiers into clearer categories. These improvements would encourage more confident decision-making and support ongoing engagement with the deeper mechanics that define Path of Exile’s identity.

Improve Combat Readability to Support Player Awareness

Combat is the heart of the moment-to-moment experience in Path of Exile 2, which makes visual clarity and situational awareness critical to user satisfaction. Player feedback highlighted consistent difficulty identifying enemy telegraphs, projectiles, and ground effects due to visual noise created by particle effects and environmental clutter. When key information is obscured, players cannot react effectively, leading to frustration and a perception that encounters feel unpredictable rather than skill-driven.

Improving combat readability should be treated as one of the most impactful opportunities for refinement. Key attacks should be visually distinct through unique silhouettes, consistent timing patterns, and color or brightness cues that remain visible during heavy action. Particle effects should be evaluated for redundancy, with opportunities to simplify or reduce visual dominance where appropriate. Strengthening damage feedback through directional indicators, clear hit reactions, and focused audio cues would further support rapid comprehension. Together, these changes would enhance fairness, promote mastery, and improve overall player trust in the combat system.

Consolidate Core Systems Into a Unified Interface

Fragmentation across the interface creates friction whenever players attempt to interact with core systems such as crafting, skill management, and gem modification. These features are distributed across multiple menus and NPC interactions, each with its own layout and structure. Because related actions are not grouped intuitively, players must

rely on memory rather than interface logic, which slows progression and increases frustration, even for experienced users.

A unified character management interface would significantly improve usability. Consolidating crafting, passive allocation, gear modification, and gem interactions into a single, tab-based layout would create a predictable and cohesive workflow. Consistent formatting and cross navigation would remove unnecessary steps and create an intuitive framework that could grow sustainably alongside future content. This centralization would immediately reduce user confusion and reinforce a more seamless progression experience.

Introduce Predictive Feedback for Crafting and Passive Selection

Complex systems require clear forward-looking feedback so that players can make informed decisions. Path of Exile 2 currently provides limited predictive information when players select passive nodes or initiate crafting actions. Without visual previews or outcome explanations, players must rely on trial and error, external references, or memory. This creates anxiety around irreversible mistakes and discourages experimentation.

Integrating predictive tools into these systems would greatly enhance decision confidence. Passive nodes could display temporary overlays that highlight projected stat changes or shifts in offensive and defensive capabilities. Crafting interfaces could present preview windows detailing expected outcomes or risk indicators that help players understand potential results. These additions would reduce uncertainty, encourage creativity, and support deeper engagement with the game’s complex mechanics.

Reduce Dependence on External Tools by Integrating Key Features

Path of Exile has historically relied on external community tools for essential functionality such as build planning, loot filtering, and modifier interpretation. While this demonstrates strong community involvement, it also reflects gaps in the internal interface. Players should not need to leave the game to perform tasks that directly influence gameplay.

Incorporating these capabilities directly into the game would significantly elevate user experience. A built-in build planner would allow players to simulate future routes, store alternate plans, and experiment safely. A customizable loot filter system would help players highlight meaningful drops based on their build or preferences. An in-game knowledge base could offer searchable explanations of modifiers, crafting mechanics, and skill interactions. These integrations would reduce friction, strengthen immersion, and ensure that critical information remains accessible to players at all times.

Strengthen Onboarding and Early Game Guidance for New Players

As Path of Exile 2 attracts new audiences, the onboarding experience must support early learning without overwhelming players. The passive skill tree currently appears highly complex from the outset, and item modifiers use terminology that can be difficult to interpret without prior knowledge. Crafting introduces layered mechanics before foundational concepts have been explained, creating early barriers to understanding.

Improving onboarding through contextual, step-by-step guidance would significantly enhance accessibility. Simplified early tooltips, temporary introductory modes, and tutorial prompts that appear during key decision moments would help new players form mental models without feeling overwhelmed. These improvements would create a more welcoming first impression and increase the likelihood that new players develop long-term engagement with the game.

Improve Inventory Efficiency to Support Gameplay Flow

Inventory management is experienced by every player, making it a high-priority area for refinement. The current grid-based system requires frequent rearranging due to mismatched item sizes, while unclear modifier grouping forces players to re-read text repeatedly during gear evaluation. These interruptions slow down gameplay, disrupt momentum, and reduce the satisfaction of looting.

Enhancing inventory efficiency would have an immediate positive impact across all personas. Automatic sorting tools, dedicated storage for crafting materials, and rapid comparison features that highlight stat changes would improve workflow dramatically. Grouping modifiers by type and adjusting formatting to emphasize key information would further support quick decision-making.

Standardize System Communication Across Interfaces

Many of the usability issues identified across items, skills, passives, and crafting stem from inconsistencies in terminology, formatting, and visual structure. When similar types of information appear in different formats across systems, players must repeatedly adjust to new patterns rather than relying on established conventions. This increases cognitive load and disrupts the continuity of the experience.

Developing a unified standard for communication across the interface would significantly improve usability. Consistent tooltip formatting, shared terminology, standardized layout structures, and predictable interaction patterns would ensure that players understand how to interpret information regardless of which system they are using. Once established, these standards would improve immediate usability and create a scalable foundation for future expansions and updates.

Contact info

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